

Trophy

Two Spoons, Then This: Neumann Wins by 13

The only man in the field without a Trophy to his name led after every round of TEG 16 and finished ahead of the defending champion, Gregg Williams, in all four.

Stuart Neumann won the TEG 16 Trophy with 156 Stableford points, finishing 13 clear of Gregg Williams. It is the second-highest total of his career.

The lead was established early and never handed back. Neumann headed the standings after the second round at Troia, headed them again after the third at Penha Longa, and was still there when Estoril closed the matter. Williams led the Green Jacket on gross throughout the same stretch. The two competitions ran on parallel tracks and never once looked like meeting.

The golf was not immaculate. He arrived at Estoril's 8th, a par four and the hardest hole on the card at stroke index 1, with the title

effectively banked. He made nine. A quintuple bogey, worth no points whatsoever. It was an act of serene indifference to his own scorecard, the sort a man can afford when he is 13 points clear, and it cost him nothing beyond tidiness.

Estoril otherwise produced his best golf of the four days. His 92 there was a course personal best on his second visit, fourteen strokes better than the 106 he posted at the same venue in TEG 15. He did not improve on his previous marks at Penha Longa or Oitavos Dunes, and Troia was new ground for the whole field. But the Trophy is decided on points across four rounds, and nobody accumulated them as steadily as he did.

AT A GLANCE
Trophy Winner Stuart Neumann (1st Trophy) Runner-up: Gregg Williams
Green Jacket Gregg Williams (2nd Jacket) Runner-up: David Mullin
Wooden Spoon Alex Baker (3rd Spoon) Next above: Jon Baker

FINAL · Trophy
SN 156 | GW 143 | DM 142 | JB 131 | AB 127
FINAL · Green Jacket
GW +66 | DM +82 | JB +93 | SN +105 | AB +148

Green Jacket

Williams Breaks It Open at Penha Longa

Four shots up going into R3 and sixteen up at the finish: the defending Jacket holder's +66 is the lowest gross he has posted in a TEG, and David Mullin was never close enough to ask a question.

Gregg Williams won the TEG 16 Green Jacket at +66, sixteen shots clear of David Mullin. It is the lowest gross total he has recorded in a TEG, the best of his career on that measure.

It was not achieved cleanly. Troia, a first visit for the field, was where he leaked most: four holes without a net par from the 8th, then three consecutive double bogeys at 13, 14 and 15, six shots to par surrendered in a row and no sign of

anybody stopping it. He signed for 94. At Penha Longa the next day he made a triple at the 3rd and a double at the 4th, then a birdie at the 5th to steady things, then a bogey, a triple and a double through 6 to 8 to unsteady them again. The round only settled late: five holes from the 11th without dropping a gross shot, including nine Stableford points across 13 to 15. His 87 was five worse than his previous best there.

The finish was the point. At Estoril he ran three pars from the 6th for another nine points, dropped a double at the 9th, and took eight at the par-four 14th. He still went round in 80, six better than his 86 there in TEG 15 and a course best. Mullin returned the same number on the same afternoon, which rather took the shine off the exclusivity, if not the Jacket.

David Mullin

Mullin's 80 Is the Lowest Estoril Has Seen

The nine-time Jacket winner was 13 shots worse at Penha Longa than on his last visit, then took 18 fewer strokes the very next day.

David Mullin's tournament turned on a single afternoon. His third round at Penha Longa, the Robert Trent Jones Jr. mountain parkland at Sintra, came apart for a gross 98 and 30 Stableford points, thirteen strokes worse than his last visit and thirteen adrift of the 85 he had posted there in TEG 15. The damage was concentrated at the 16th, the hardest hole on the card, where he took eight for no points at all. He then made two pars to finish, which is the golfing equivalent of straightening the pictures on the way out of a burning house.

What followed at Estoril was the best round TEG has recorded on the Mackenzie Ross parkland. Mullin went round in 80 gross, taking six strokes off the previous course record of 86 set across six earlier visits, and beating his own 94 there from TEG 15 by fourteen. It was worth 45 points, a fifteen-point improvement on the day before.

It was not untroubled. A birdie at the 2nd and a par at the 3rd gave way to bogeys at the 4th and 5th and a double bogey at the 6th, before a birdie at the 7th arrested the decline. The scoring came in a burst through the middle: a bogey at the 11th and pars at the 12th and 13th brought nine points in three holes, and he closed with pars at the 16th and 17th.

For context on how far he had travelled, Mullin had been bottom of the TEG 16 Wooden Spoon race by the 10th hole of round one, after a triple bogey at Oitavos Dunes.

Wooden Spoon | Alex Baker

Two Course Records, Both the Wrong Way

Alex Baker was bottom of the TEG 16 Trophy table after all four rounds, and left Oitavos Dunes and Estoril with higher gross scores than TEG has ever recorded at either.

Alex Baker took the TEG 16 Wooden Spoon with 127 points, and collected two course-worst marks en route, which suggests a man committed to leaving a mark on the record books by any available method.

The first arrived at once. His 113 gross at Oitavos Dunes in round one is the highest score recorded on the course, beating the previous worst of 111 set across twelve earlier visits. Three holes did most of it: a nine at the 1st, another nine at the 11th, and a ten at the 17th. It was also ten strokes worse than his own best at Oitavos, the 103 he posted in TEG 15.

Troia, new to the roster, offered him a five-hole slide from the 13th to the 17th in which he dropped thirteen shots to par. Penha Longa produced a 106, level with his best previous round there, and by that stage level was a triumph.

Estoril supplied the second record. Baker opened with a nine at the 1st, added an eight at the 3rd and a nine at the 6th, and between the 5th and the 10th leaked fourteen shots, three of those holes passing without a net par. Then came the 12th. Eleven strokes. A septuple bogey, and the worst score relative to par he has recorded on any hole in TEG history. The round finished at 107 gross, above Estoril's previous worst of 106 from six prior visits, and eight strokes adrift of the 99 he shot there in TEG 15. Two courses will remember him. Neither fondly.

Alex Baker | Jon Baker

The Bakers Both Break at the Twelfth

Penha Longa's 12th is stroke index 17, one of the easiest holes on the card; in R3 it took a 10 off Jon Baker and a 9 off Alex Baker, and neither brother made a net par anywhere near it.

The third round at Penha Longa, the Atlantic Course at Sintra, dismantled both Bakers in the same place, at the same time, with no apparent discrimination between them. The trouble began at the 11th, a par 4 and the hardest hole on the card, where Jon Baker and Alex Baker each made 6. It deepened at the 12th, a par 5 rated stroke index 17 and therefore, on paper, the gentlest hole on the property. Jon took 10, a quintuple bogey. Alex took 9. The stroke index had clearly been drawn up by an optimist.

Neither man found the exit quickly. Jon followed with a quadruple-bogey 8 at the 13th, completing a three-hole run from the 11th that cost him 11 shots to par and yielded exactly one Stableford point. Alex made 7 at the 13th and 7 again at the 14th, twelve shots dropped across four holes, with no net par anywhere between the 12th and the 14th.

Jon signed for 97 at a course where he had previously gone round in 85, twelve strokes better than this. Alex signed for 106, which matched his own best score at Penha Longa, set back in TEG 8. Consistency of a sort.

Jon's difficulties travelled with him to Estoril the following day, where he took 8 at the par-4 11th, the second-hardest hole there. It is a measure of the round that he still came home in 93, three shots better than his previous best at the course.

Records & Personal Bests

Notable achievements: TEG 16

Rare Feats

— Alex Baker runs up an 11 (+7) at the 12th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-4